English Phrases for Phone and Video Calls at Work

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SEO essentials

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Meta title	English Phrases for Phone and Video Calls at Work
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Phone and video calls in English are harder than talking face-to-face — and it's not just you. **Without body language to help, and with audio that can cut out, calls demand clearer, more structured language.** The fix is to have ready phrases for each predictable moment: starting the call, handling audio problems, taking turns, and wrapping up.

This is especially useful for remote and call-centre work, where most of your English happens over a line. Learn the phrases below, and calls stop being something to dread and become routine.

Starting a call

Answering the phone:

- "Hello, this is [name] speaking."
- "[Company], [name] speaking — how can I help you?"

Making a call / introducing yourself:

- “Hi, this is [name] from [company]. Is now a good time to talk?”
- “I’m calling about…”
- “Could I speak to [name], please?”

Joining a video call:

- “Hi everyone, can you hear me okay?”
- “Sorry I’m a minute late — thanks for waiting.”
- “Let me just turn my camera on.”

Small talk to open:

- “Thanks for making the time.”
- “How are things on your end?”

When there's an audio or tech problem

This is the part that catches learners out — but there are standard phrases for it, and using them is completely normal:

You can’t hear them:

- “Sorry, you’re breaking up — could you say that again?”
- “I’m having trouble hearing you. Could you speak up a little?”
- “I think the connection dropped for a second.”

You didn’t understand:

- “Sorry, could you repeat that?”
- “Could you say that more slowly, please?”
- “Just to confirm, you said…?”

Your own tech issues:

- “Can everyone hear me? I’m not sure my mic is working.”
- “My connection is unstable — I may drop off and rejoin.”
- “Let me turn my video off to help the connection.”

Managing the moment:

- “Sorry, I think we talked over each other — please go ahead.”
- “You go first.”

Asking someone to repeat or slow down is never rude on a call — everyone does it, and it’s far better than guessing.

During the call

Stating the purpose:

- “The reason I’m calling is…”
- “There are a couple of things I’d like to go over.”

Taking turns (harder without body language):

- “Can I jump in here?”
- “Go ahead, [name].”
- “I’ll let you finish.”
- “Did you want to add anything?”

Checking and confirming:

- “Just to make sure we’re on the same page…”
- “Could you clarify what you mean by…?”
- “Let me repeat that back to you.”

On video specifically:

- “I’ll share my screen now — can you see it?”
- “I’ll put myself on mute while you talk.”
- “Sorry, I was on mute!” (a universal one)

On calls, it helps to pause a beat before speaking so you don’t talk over anyone — the slight audio delay makes overlaps common.

Ending the call

Wrapping up:

- “I think that covers everything — anything else before we finish?”
- “Thanks, that was really helpful.”

Confirming next steps:

- “So just to confirm the next steps…”
- “I’ll send a follow-up email with a summary.”
- “Let’s catch up again next week.”
- “I’ll get that over to you by [day].”

Signing off:

- “Thanks again for your time. Have a great day!”

- “Great to talk — speak soon.”
- “Bye for now.”

Ending with a clear summary of who does what by when is especially valuable on calls, where things are easy to mishear — it leaves no doubt about what was agreed.

Tips for calls as a non-native speaker

- **Keep key phrases visible.** On a call, no one can see your notes — so keep a list of these phrases on-screen or beside you until they're automatic.
- **Slow down and speak clearly.** Audio strips out some clarity, so crisp pronunciation and a slightly slower pace matter more on a call than in person.
- **Don't fear the “repeat that” phrases.** Using them is normal and professional, not a sign of weak English.
- **Prepare your opening and your purpose** before you dial — the first 20 seconds are the most nerve-wracking.

The real challenge is that calls are audio-first — you can't rely on gestures — which is exactly why voice practice helps so much. With an AI speaking partner like Yappply, you practise in the same voice-only mode a call uses: you talk, it responds, and you get feedback on clarity and phrasing. Rehearsing calls this way — a quick role-play of answering the phone, handling a dropped connection, confirming next steps — makes the real ones feel routine. If calls are where your English feels hardest, voice practice is the most direct way to fix it.

Frequently asked questions

Why are English phone calls harder than talking in person? Because you lose body language and facial expressions that normally help you understand, and audio can be unclear or cut out. That makes clear language and ready phrases more important on calls.

What do I say when I can't hear someone on a call? Use standard phrases like “Sorry, you're breaking up — could you say that again?” or “I'm having trouble hearing you, could you speak up a little?” These are completely normal on calls.

How do I answer a business phone call in English? “Hello, this is [name] speaking” or “[Company], [name] speaking — how can I help you?” Then listen, and use “The reason I'm calling is…” or ask how you can help.

Is it rude to ask someone to repeat or slow down on a call? No — it's normal and professional, and native speakers do it too. It's far better to ask than to guess and misunderstand something important.

How can I practise English for phone and video calls? Practise in voice-only mode: role-play answering a call, handling a dropped connection, and confirming next steps out loud. An AI speaking partner is ideal because it mirrors the audio-first nature of a real call and gives feedback.